

Lecture 2: What is government? What is politics?

GOVT2305: Federal Government

Instructor: Tom Hanna, Spring 2026

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1. Agenda and Announcements

1.1 Agenda

- Today

- What is Government? What is politics?
- Discussion: Experiences with Government
- Questions

- Next class (Monday):

- Basic ethics
- Discussion of personal ethics

- Tuesday:

- Constitutional Safeguards
- Ethics and limits on government discussion (why do we need Constitutional safeguards? What should be prevented?)

1.2 Assignments Upcoming

- Journals for Next Monday (suggested schedule):

- Chapter 1: Political Thinking and Political Culture: Becoming a Responsible Citizen
- Chapter 2: Constitutional Democracy: Promoting Liberty and Self-Government

- Journals for Next Tuesday (suggested):

- Chapter 3: Federalism: Forging a Nation
- Chapter 4: Civil Liberties: Protecting Individual Rights

- Module 1 Journals deadline July 20

- Study Guide Module 1

- Due July 17
- Quiz July 20 beginning of class

2. Introduction to Government

2.1 Introduction to Government

To really understand government and politics we first need to know what those things are.

2.2 Introduction Government: Questions to consider

What is government or “The State”?

2.3 A word on words

- Government can mean multiple things

- The specific group of people in charge of...
- The enduring institution or organization we call government

- State has at least three meanings

- International: State = independent country
- United States: State = one of the 50 states
- Political Science: State = government

- Politics

- The process of making collective decisions in the context of the state or government

2.4 What is government?

How can we define government?

- What government does?

2.5 What is government?

How can we define government?

- What government does?

- Then what is politics?

- What makes government unique?

- What does this make politics?

2.6 What government does?

Before stepping on the campus today, what was the last time that politics made a difference in your life?

2.7 What is politics?

- **Expensive or involves large amounts of money**
- **Distant**
- **Involves politicians or campaigns**
- **involves voting or decision making**
- **Involves rights**
- **National borders**
- **Controversial**

2.8 What is politics: State and local (mostly)



Houston Public Works

2.9 What is politics: Federal, state and local



Metro rail

2.10 What is politics: Federal, state and local



HCC Central Campus

2.11 What is politics?

- **Not distant**
- **immediate, right here**
- **touches everything**
- **direct impacts are constant**
- **involves all of us**
- **It can be expensive, but it's not always about money**

2.12 Politics is powerful

- Immense power to achieve good ends

2.13 Politics is powerful

- Immense power to achieve good ends
- Immense power to do incredible harm

2.14 Politics is powerful

- Immense power to achieve good ends
- Immense power to do incredible harm

2.15 Politics is powerful

Why does politics have such power to cause harm?

2.16 What does government do?

These are all examples of *collective action*, organized action by a group of people to achieve a common goal.

2.17 What makes government different?

What makes government or The State different from other organizations? Is collective action unique to government?

2.18 Other organizations - Group 1

- Family
 - What does it have in common?
 - What is different?

2.19 Other organizations

- Family
- Church
 - What does it (government) have in common?
 - What is different?

2.20 Other organizations

- Family
- Church
- Community organizations (voluntary)
 - What does it have in common?
 - What is different?

2.21 Other organizations

- Family

- Church
- Community organizations (voluntary)
- Charities

- What does it have in common?
- What is different?

2.22 Other organizations

- Family
- Church
- Community organizations (voluntary)
- Charities
- Businesses - The Market

- What does it have in common?
- What is different?

2.23 Other organizations - Group 2

- Organized crime

- What does it have in common?
- What is different?

2.24 Other organizations

- Organized crime
- vigilantes

- What does it have in common?
- What is different?

2.25 Other organizations

- Organized crime
- vigilantes
- terrorists

- What does it have in common?
- What is different?

2.26 Other organizations

- For the Group 1 organizations, how can they enforce their rules?

For the Group 2 organizations, who are they responsible to and how do we view their use of force?

2.27 What is “the state”?

The organized, coercive use of violent force commonly accepted as legitimate

- organized
- Coercive use
- violent force (armed force)
- Legitimacy

2.28 Introduction Government: Questions to consider

What is politics?

2.29 What is politics?

- **Politics is the process of making collective decisions in the context of...**

2.30 What is politics?

- **Politics is the process of making collective decisions in the context of...**

The State or government.

2.31 The difference between politics and everything else

These organizations all engage in collective action and collective decision making, but lack one thing the state has:

- Family
- Church
- Community organizations (voluntary)
- Charities
- Businesses - The Market

2.32 The difference between politics and everything else

These organizations all engage in collective action, but lack one thing the state has:

- Family
- Church
- Community organizations (voluntary)

- Charities
- Businesses - The Market

Coercive use of violent force

2.33 Studying other organizations

Family, church, the market, etc. are all about making collective decisions in:

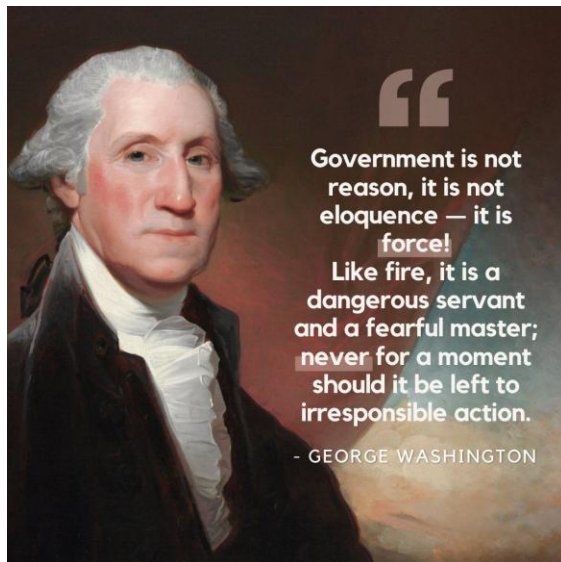
The Voluntary Sphere

2.34 Politics is about

Making collective decisions in:

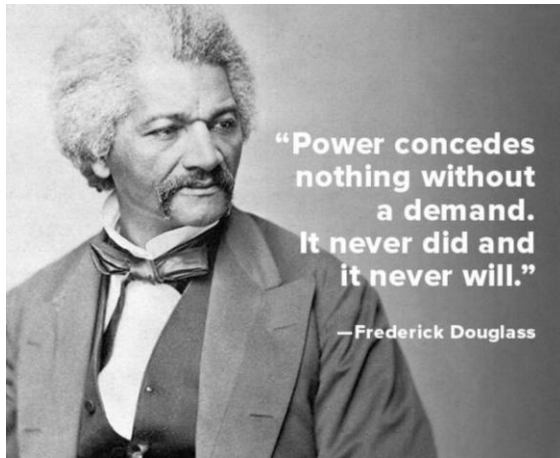
The Coercive Sphere

2.35 Politics is powerful



George Washington

2.36 Politics is powerful



Frederick Douglass

3. Canvas and e-Book Overview

4. Questions

4.1 Authorship and License

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